

WHERE THERE'S A WILL, THERE'S A WAY

When we were little, my sister and I would play a very morbid game called “Writing Your Will.” The game was that we’d sit down and write on a piece of computer paper what we’d leave to whom if we passed away. Then we’d compare notes and argue about what we wanted. Why wouldn’t she leave me her Gameboy? Why wouldn’t I leave her my Pokemon cards? What favors could I do to get more stuff in her will? What was she leaving my parents versus what I’d chosen to leave them? Whose inheritance to our extended family was nicer? We also knew these weren’t *real* wills—or so we thought.

Turns out, according to estate lawyer David Shapiro, that if a will is written in the dead person’s own handwriting, it could be legally binding—even if it’s on a piece of computer paper and drafted in crayon. (He also said some states are now allowing text messages to count as wills. What emojis will you use in your wills, guys?)

Wills are complicated, and trusts, which are supposed to eliminate some of the hassle, can also be complicated because, of course, *families* are complicated. You’re banking on there being even one reasonable responsible person in charge after a death. (In my own family, we’re all relying on my hippie aunt because the pickings are slim, y’all.)

The way my family is set up, I never assumed I was getting an inheritance. When I hear the word *inheritance*, I think about some douchebag at a boarding school in Connecticut telling his potential girlfriend that he’s all set once his trust fund kicks in. Or some other douchebag complaining about struggling to get a start-up off the ground even though all the seed money came from their parents. Or maybe the beginning of a movie where douchebag Adam Sandler has to go back to school in order to inherit his father’s company. I clearly know a